

Fast-Weight Memory Layers Improve Small Language Models at Matched Parameters and Compute

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July 2026

Abstract

We replace every second attention layer of a modern Transformer with a gated delta-rule fast-weight memory layer and evaluate the result under strict accounting: parameters matched to 0.1%, identical data, matched training budget, and pre-registered decision margins. On five procedural task families, the memory hybrid is more accurate on all five (+4.0 to +21.8 points) while spending 20–40% *fewer* inference FLOPs per correct answer (Figure 1). A 2×2 ablation attributes both effects to the delta mechanism (+22.8) rather than its sliding-window component (+3.5); doubling the baseline’s training budget does not close the gap (+25.8 on non-saturated difficulty tiers); and the preferred memory density is every second layer. At 50M parameters under a fixed recipe the advantage is task-dependent: it grows on program execution (+31.7) and reverses on state tracking (−5.2). Pricing the mechanism against visible chain-of-thought at matched per-answer FLOPs, trained rationale tokens win on accuracy — a FLOP-matched 1.7× wider model buys nothing and contentless filler tokens hurt — yet the two mechanisms *compose*: the hybrid with traces reaches 100% at ~5% lower cost than the Transformer with traces. We also characterize a bimodal training outcome: on a rule-revision task, seeds transition discontinuously to ~100% accuracy (3/16 fresh seeds, plus 2 caught mid-transition; 0/6 for the baseline), with an onset that is trajectory-nondeterministic; no early-training signal met the pre-registered predictor bar. The complete study — ten pre-registered experiments including three negative results — cost \$59 of commodity cloud compute. Code, per-run results, and pre-registrations are public.¹

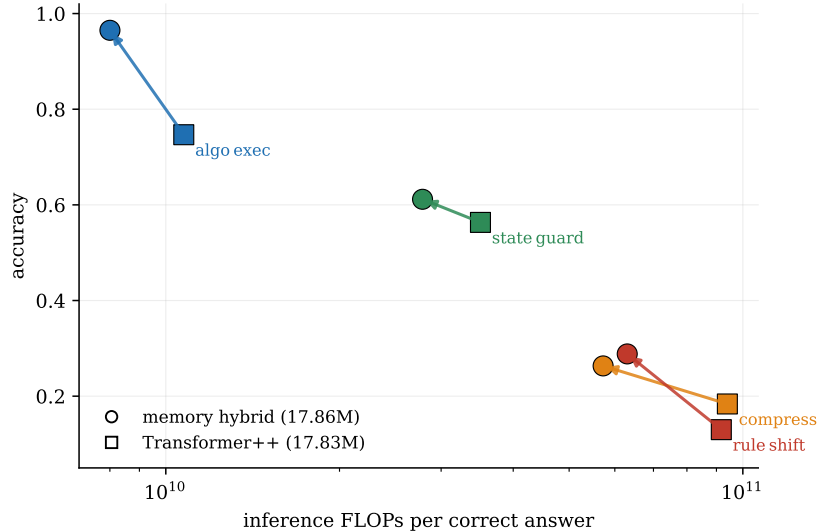


Figure 1: Main result. Accuracy versus inference FLOPs per correct answer at 17.8M parameters, same data, same training budget (means over 3–6 seeds; arrows point from Transformer++ to the memory hybrid). The hybrid is up-left — more accurate *and* cheaper per correct answer — on every family. (*dsl_learn*, +4.0, omitted for legibility.)

¹<https://github.com/dimitri-sky/fast-weight-memory-lm> (paper) and <https://github.com/dimitri-sky/aware-latent-depth> (full research program, run-level ledger).

1 Introduction

Linear-attention hybrids with delta-rule fast weights are entering production language models, yet public evidence for *why* they win is thin: papers rarely hold parameters, data, and compute fixed simultaneously, and per-answer inference cost is almost never reported. We contribute a small, fully audited data point. The question is narrow and the accounting is strict; every claim below was given a pre-registered pass/fail margin before results existed, and every number traces to a run identifier in a public ledger. Beyond the head-to-head, we price the mechanism against the two obvious alternatives at matched per-answer FLOPs — visible chain-of-thought tokens and a wider model — and against a weight-tied recurrent-depth architecture, so the reader gets one consistent exchange rate between four ways of spending inference compute.

Concretely, we compare a byte-level Transformer++ baseline (RoPE, SwiGLU, RMSNorm, GQA; 17.83M) against a hybrid that replaces every second attention layer with a *gated delta-rule fast-weight layer* [2, 1] — a linear-attention state $S_t \in \mathbb{R}^{d_k \times d_v}$ updated token-by-token with a learned write/erase gate — keeping sliding-window attention ($w=128$) on the remaining layers (17.86M, +0.1%; Figure 2), the layer pattern production hybrids have converged on [3]. Both are trained from scratch, per-family, on SAGE: five generated, contamination-audited procedural families (program execution, mid-session rule revision, in-session codebook learning, state tracking, fresh-language induction) with difficulty tiers and execution-checked scoring.

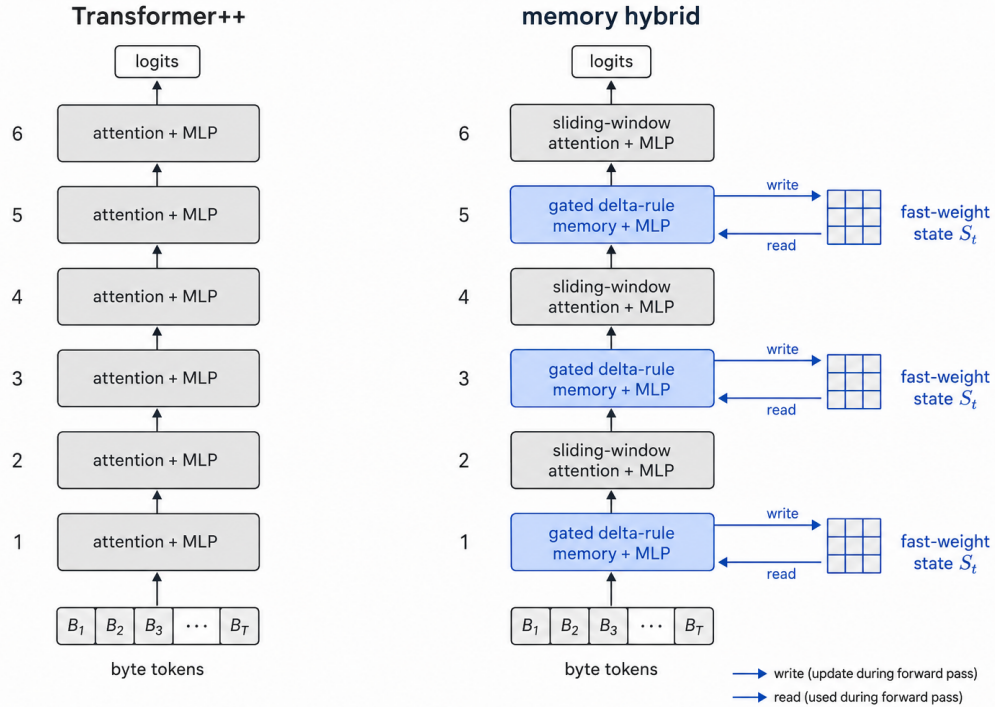


Figure 2: The two architectures. Left: the Transformer++ baseline. Right: the memory hybrid — every second block is a gated delta-rule memory layer that writes to and reads from a fast-weight state S_t during the forward pass; the remaining blocks use sliding-window attention ($w=128$).

2 Setup

Accounting. FLOPs are counted analytically (2 FLOPs per MAC) and cross-checked against PyTorch’s counter in CI (agreement within 10% enforced). Every generated token is charged a full forward pass at its context length. The efficiency metric is *inference FLOPs per correct answer*, which charges mistakes to

the model that makes them.

Protocol. 4,000 steps $\times$ batch 32 $\times$ 768 tokens per family; learning rate depth-scaled; 3 seeds by default (2–16 where noted, all stated in advance). Margins, gates, and deviations are logged in time-stamped pre-registration files; every mid-study deviation (an arm dropped for cost before its results existed; a config bug caught by a feasibility probe; one session’s results stranded by an infrastructure failure and re-run before per-tier outcomes were seen) is recorded there at decision time.

3 Results

3.1 The memory hybrid wins on all five families, at lower cost

Table 1: 18M head-to-head. Mean accuracy $\pm$ SD over seeds; Welch t reported per family. FLOPs/correct is inference cost per correct answer. Superscripts give seed counts where they differ from 3.

family	Transformer++	memory hybrid	Δ	Welch t	FLOPs/correct ratio
algo_exec	.747 $\pm$.016	.965 $\pm$.009	+21.8	20.7	0.75 $\times$
rule_shift ^{6s}	.130 $\pm$.034	.288 $\pm$.349	+15.8	1.1	0.69 $\times$
compress	.184 $\pm$.009	.263 $\pm$.032	+7.9	4.1	0.61 $\times$
state_guard	.563 $\pm$.043	.612 $\pm$.028	+4.8	1.7	0.79 $\times$
dsl_learn ^{2s}	.165 $\pm$.014	.205 $\pm$.021	+4.0	2.2	—

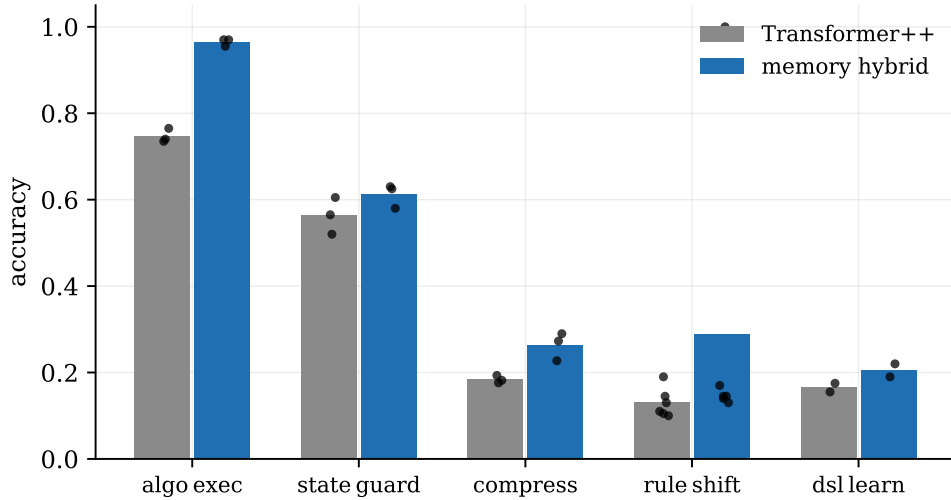


Figure 3: Per-family accuracy with individual seeds (dots). The hybrid leads on 5/5 families; **rule_shift**’s variance is the bimodality of Figure 8.

The pooled family-mean gap is +13.5 points against a pre-registered +3.0 margin. Statistical honesty: the gap is individually significant on the two largest effects (algo_exec $t=20.7$, compress $t=4.1$) and directional but not individually significant on the rest at these seed counts; **rule_shift**’s mean is dominated by one grokked seed (median gap +2.5). The pre-registered 2 $\times$ pooled-SD stability gate fails for exactly this reason, and we report it as such.

3.2 Attribution: the delta mechanism, not the window

The hybrid differs from the baseline in two ways, so we complete the 2 $\times$ 2 (Figure 4). Adding the sliding window alone moves the baseline +3.5; adding delta layers alone moves it +22.8 (.975, slightly *above* the

full hybrid); the interaction is -4.5 . The window also fails to reproduce any memory-family gain (state tracking *degrades* by 4.1). A pre-registered prediction was falsified here: we expected the window to explain the FLOP discount, but the discount is also delta-driven — the window trims only $\sim 7\%$ of FLOPs; the rest comes through the accuracy denominator.

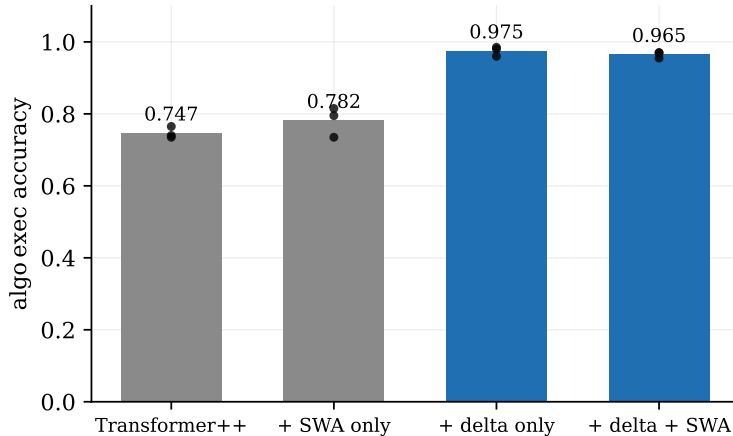


Figure 4: 2×2 ablation on `algo_exec` (3 seeds each, dots). The delta mechanism carries the effect.

3.3 Doubling the baseline’s training budget does not close the gap

If delta layers merely *optimize faster*, more training should let the baseline catch up. At $2\times$ steps the baseline improves ($.747 \rightarrow .795$ — the arm discriminates) but the gap on non-saturated tiers (3–5) remains $+25.8$ points against a pre-registered pass bar of half the original gap (Figure 5). A ceiling guard (hybrid $> .95$ overall) moved the primary read to hard tiers, as pre-registered.

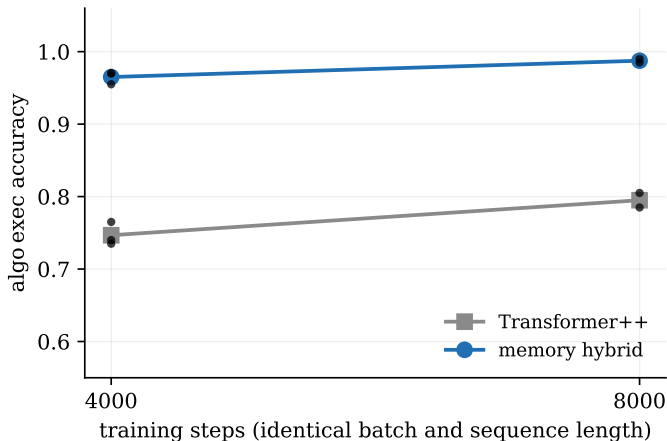


Figure 5: Training-budget robustness on `algo_exec`.

3.4 At 50M the advantage is task-dependent

Scaling both models to 50.5M (-0.05% param match) under the same recipe: the program-execution gap *grows* to $+31.7$ while the state-tracking gap *reverses* to -5.2 (Figure 6). A caveat cuts both ways: the 50M baseline underperforms its own 18M counterpart on `algo_exec`, indicating the fixed recipe undertrains at

this size — part of the growth is baseline weakness, and the reversal may be a tuning artifact. We therefore make no uniform-scaling claim.

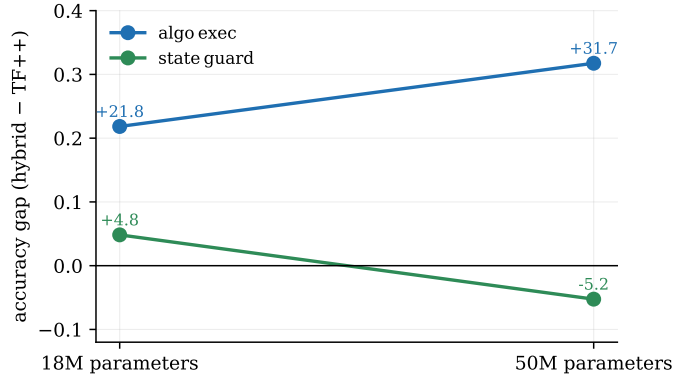


Figure 6: Accuracy gap at 18M vs. 50M (fixed training recipe, 2 seeds at 50M).

3.5 Pricing latent memory against visible chain-of-thought

Fast-weight memory is one way to buy computation at inference time; generating rationale tokens is another, and whether latent computation can substitute for visible traces is an open thread [5]. We price both on the same axis (Figure 7): Transformer++ variants trained to emit a **THINK: ... ANSWER:** trace at three granularities (the budget knob is trace granularity at training time — eval-time truncation is an invalid instrument, since a truncated trace never reaches **ANSWER:**), a contentless length-matched filler control, and a $1.7\times$ wider model (30.76M, $d=672$) sized analytically so its direct per-answer FLOPs match the long-trace arm within 1.8%. Every generated token is charged a full forward pass at its context length; the primary read is tier 3–5 accuracy, all margins pre-registered at +3.0 points.

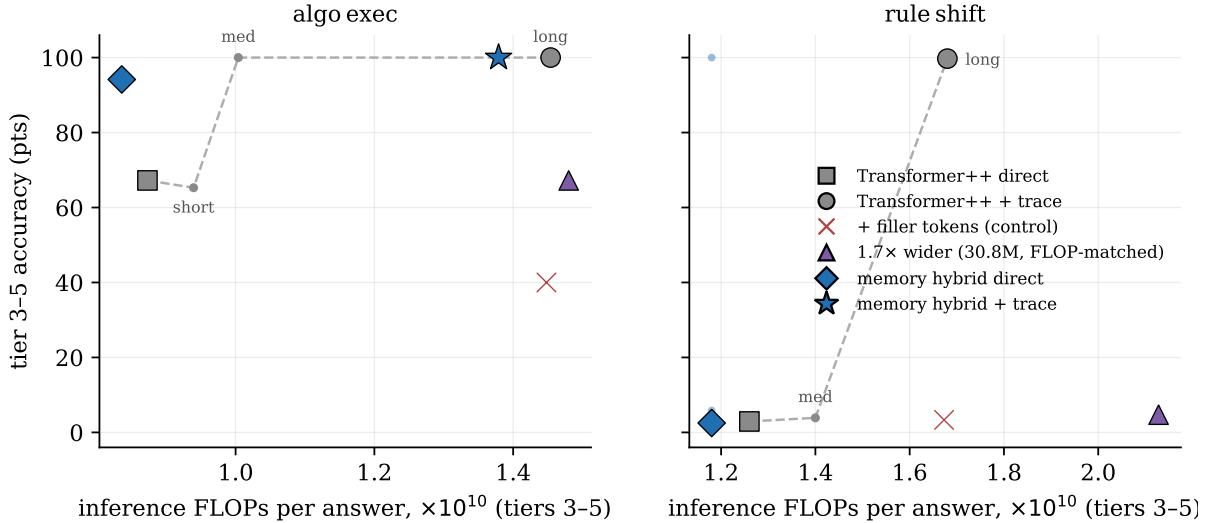


Figure 7: Four ways to spend inference compute, priced on one axis (tier 3–5 accuracy vs. measured FLOPs per answer; trace granularity annotated along the dashed budget curve). Small dots on **rule_shift**’s hybrid-direct marker are individual seeds — the median is plotted because of the bimodality of Figure 8.

Four pre-registered gates, all decisive. **(1) Trained traces pay:** +32.8 over direct on program execution (best budget) and +96.8 on rule revision. **(2) The win is content, not compute:** filler tokens

at identical length and FLOPs are null on rule revision (+0.4) and *negative* on program execution (−27.2) — no pause-token [4] free lunch at this scale. **(3) Tokens beat parameters:** the FLOP-matched wider model buys +0.0 and +1.8 over its own 17.8M baseline. **(4) Visible beats latent on accuracy, and the crossover is cheap:** the hybrid holds a 27-point edge over the direct baseline at $0.96\times$ its cost, but a medium-granularity trace passes it (100.0) at $1.20\times$ the hybrid’s FLOPs; on rule revision the full-table trace converts the grokking lottery of \$3.6 into 99.7 on every seed — traces buy *reliability*, not just accuracy. Accuracy is not monotone in trace budget: sparse every-third-step traces score at or below direct (65.3), so the trace’s step-by-step structure, not its token count, carries the effect.

The mechanisms compose rather than compete: the memory hybrid trained with long traces reaches 100.0 on all tiers, both seeds, at $\sim 5\%$ fewer FLOPs per answer than the Transformer++ with the same traces — the trace does the heavy lifting and the delta layers trim the cost. Scope: trained, task-aligned, in-distribution rationales under greedy decoding; the FLOP axis spans only $1.0\text{--}1.7\times$ direct because prefill dominates at these prompt shapes — itself a deployment-relevant observation (short-prompt regimes price visible reasoning very low).

3.6 Bimodal skill acquisition, replicated

On `rule_shift`, five of six hybrid seeds land at .13–.17 and one reaches 1.00 (train loss 0.0014) — a discontinuous transition absent in all six baseline seeds (Figure 8). Same data, same configuration, different initialization. Artifact checks: all twelve runs share one eval split and scorer (a bug would inflate every seed); training data is identical across seeds; the contamination audit passed; and the transition is visible in the training loss, not only the eval score.

A pre-registered replication on 16 fresh seeds (disjoint seed range, byte-identical config) confirms the phenomenon: 3/16 grok (Wilson 95% CI [.07, .43], consistent with the original 1/6), two more are caught mid-transition when the 4,000-step budget ends (.885, .64), and eleven stay flat. Instrumented probes place transition onsets at steps 1,000–2,600, so “rare discrete event” is better read as “slow transition that often does not fit the budget.” A same-seed re-run of the original grokked seed reached only .695 — onset is trajectory-nondeterministic, not seed-determined. The predictor question came back negative: across seven pre-registered early-training signals (loss curvature, gradient norms, fast-weight state norm and effective rank, gate drift, weight-norm ratios, early tier-1 probe accuracy), none separated grokked from flat runs at the pre-registered bar within the first 1,000 steps — a $k=2$ state-norm separation broke at $k=3$.

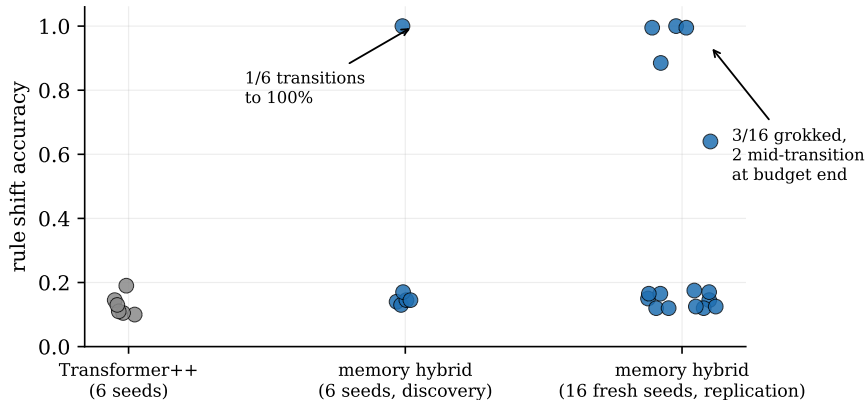


Figure 8: Seed-level outcomes on `rule_shift`: the original 6-seed head-to-head and the pre-registered 16-seed replication (fresh seeds, identical config).

3.7 Negative control: recurrent depth does not pay here

For completeness: in the same program, weight-tied loop architectures [6, 7] (prelude–core $\times K$ –coda) failed to pay their FLOP cost twice — vanilla loops lose to a step-matched control (consistent with independent

iso-FLOP analyses [11]), and the current best training recipe (per-loop supervision [9], randomized loop counts, truncated BPTT [10]) twice produced *loop-invariant* models, detected only by a pre-registered diagnostic that evaluates the same checkpoint at $K=1$ vs. $K=4$ (< 2 -point gap against a 5-point gate) — the readout blind spot of [8]. Latent computation helped here only when it carried *writable state across the sequence*, not when it re-applied the same transformation in depth.

4 Limitations

15–50M scale; procedural byte-level benchmark; per-family specialists (no multi-task control); one window size; 2–16 seeds per arm; the 50M recipe untuned. The chain-of-thought comparison measures trained, in-distribution rationales under greedy decoding — not prompted or noisy ones — and its training FLOPs are reported but not matched across arms (the claim is scoped to inference-time economics, as pre-registered). The delta scan is implemented sequentially, so wall-clock favors the baseline (FLOP counts are implementation-independent; chunked-parallel kernels for this layer family exist in production systems). Small-scale results do not license frontier claims; the mechanism family is already validated at scale by others — what this study adds is the controlled, matched, pre-registered evidence chain and the per-answer cost accounting.

5 Reproducibility

All pre-registrations (`agent/log/EXP-*.md`), the 1,600-row run ledger (`experiments/results.csv`), frozen configs, adjudication scripts, and a two-minute demo (`scripts/demo.py`: fresh puzzles, both models side-by-side, live FLOPs-per-correct meter) are public. Total compute: one local RTX 3080 plus commodity RTX 5090 pod-hours; \$59 across the two study arcs (\$38 architecture, \$21 chain-of-thought economics and grokking replication).

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